

Eagle #2, Smith, and Corkscrew Death Valley M-Rock Provisional

Peaks: Eagle #2 (DPS), Smith (DPS), and Corkscrew (DPS)

Leaders: Matthew Hengst, Kathy Rich

January 16th 2010 to January 17th 2010

After the minor adventure two weeks previous where Kim and I had to bivy on a small rocky ledge part way down Eagle mountain I was once again sleeping in the bed of my truck at the base of the mountain beside the dry Amaragosa riverbed. This time instead of it being just Kim and I it was me and 7 intrepid Sierra Club members who had driven out to spend two days following me up three different peaks in the Death Valley area.

Complicating matters slightly was the forecast which called for a not insignificant amount of rain starting Sunday night. Considering where we were, the length of dirt roads we'd be driving, and the possibility of flooding I was very aware of the potential for problems. Then again, considering the events of my previous provisional's it wouldn't do for things to go too smoothly.

As usual I drove out late Friday night and arrived at the trailhead outside of Shoshone sometime after midnight. Rather than bother with a tent I just threw my pad out in the back of my truck and went to sleep near what I rather hoped were the tents of my co-leader and at least some of my participants.

Around 2 am I awoke to the sound of a truck nearby and ended up taking a short walk to discover another late arrival looking for the site through a minor maze of very faint dirt roads.

Day 1: A beautiful climb of Eagle #2. And there was Smith.

All in all it was a pleasant if rather short night and when 5 am rolled around I rolled out of my bag and started getting ready.



As it turns out those were my participants in the tents and the few who were missing soon turned up when it became light enough for them to see us from where they had camped just down the road.

There was paperwork galore to fill out as this was an official Sierra Club restricted mountaineering trip so between that and the usual morning tasks I was quite busy. Finally 7 am rolled around and it was time to go!



We set out across the desert floor at a brisk pace angling directly for a prominent gully to the south of the peak. We were a strong group though there were a few grumbles at the energetic pace I set. Still, before long we were to the fun stuff, the rock!



We strapped on our helmets and headed up.



The route had fairly basic rock until near the summit but it was very pretty as the canyon we entered via a ridge soon became a canyon with tall rock walls towering above us.



This continued until we hit the summit ridge where we had some additional class 3 rock which was a bit more challenging. The biggest challenge was hitting the approach to the summit ridge which I managed straight on.

Once we made the ridge we had beautiful views in all directions.



We made our way along the ridge towards the high point.



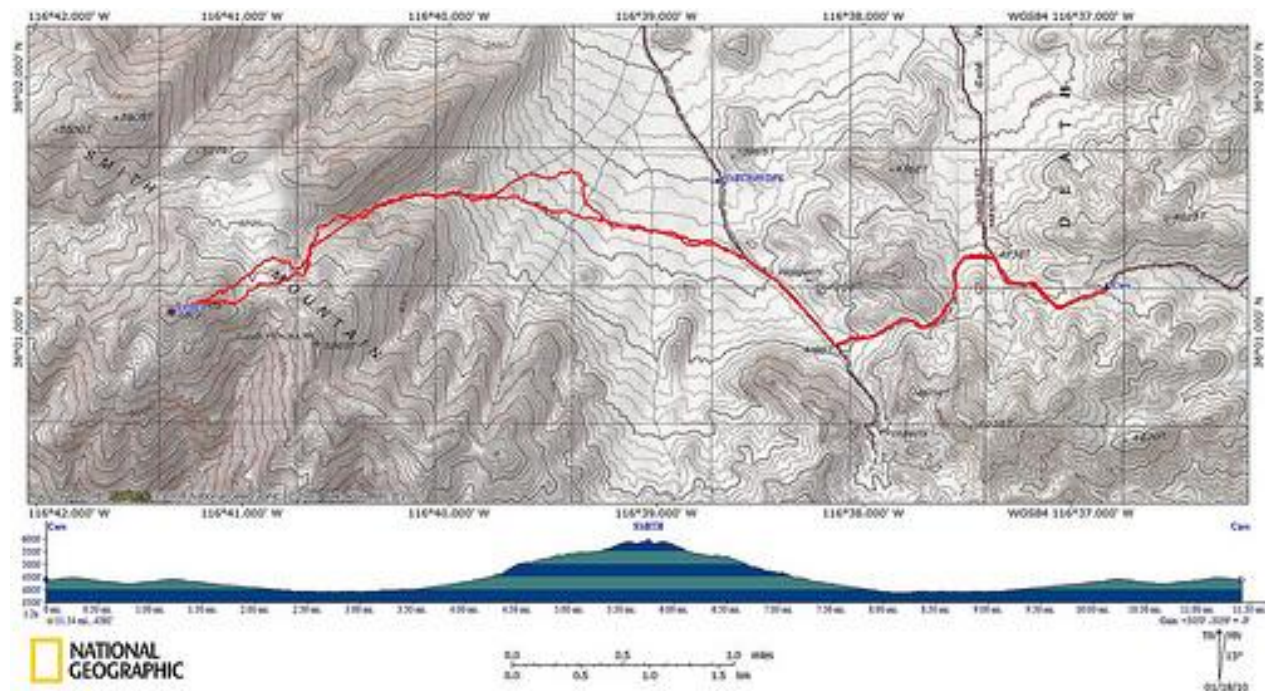
Our intrepid band upon the summit.



Now came the descent which is always more challenging and time when your most likely to have something go wrong. In particular with rock things you can shoot up on the ascent provide a bit more of a challenge going down as you have to watch your balance when you transition from standing to climbing down and take a bit more care with feet placement.

The descent is where we had the only real trouble when one of the participants slipped on a loose rock and went down in a rather scary looking somersault. I hurried back to his side but fortunately it was just a minor bruise along with a banged up knee. It did slow us down a bit and by the time we were back at the cars it was noon.

...And Smith



Now came the tricky part. Eagle by itself wasn't enough to fill the day and Kathy, who had been nice enough to act as my provisional evaluator, had an additional peak in the area she needed. So the plan was to drive out and bag nearby Smith Mountain.

Smith was only about 35 miles away, not bad at all, but 20 of those miles were on dirt roads and the last 10 were marked 4WD required by the park.

I warned everyone there was a very strong chance of this turning into a headlamp hike on the way back (after all, it's not a Matt hike unless you get to use your headlamp) but we had a willing group and we mounted up and took off.



The dirt roads weren't as bad as I had feared though eventually I reached a spot where my 2WD Chevy S10 had had enough and I started spinning tires.

This left us with several miles of dirt road walking in addition to the published route. Also, the person who had slipped on Eagle was in enough pain he opted to remain in camp.



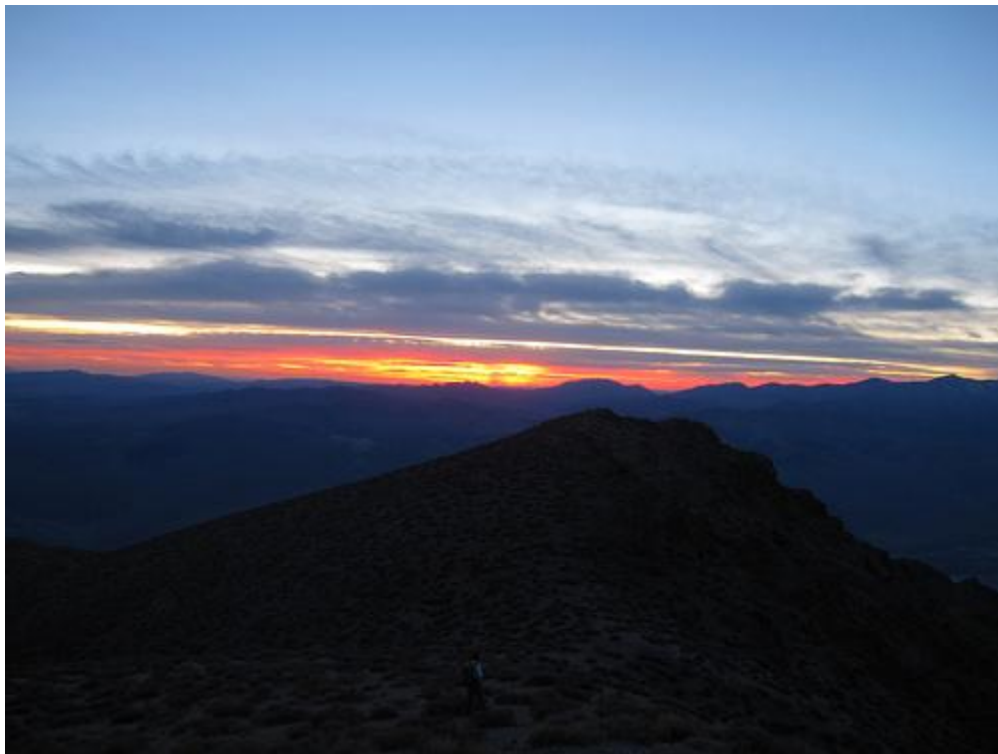
The remainder set out with me down the road and after a few miles cut across a large open area for a rather obvious canyon. We made good time as everyone had an eye on the sun which was starting to drop for the horizon.



Once in the canyon the aesthetics improved dramatically though we had a few spots where climbing loose terrain was required.



We popped out of the far end of the canyon and could see several peaks ahead of us in the rapidly failing light. My group was somewhat less than enthusiastic when I explained that Smith was the furthest of them but we pressed on.



We made the Smith just as the sun went down and enjoyed a few short minutes of a rather spectacular sunset. Then it was time to put on the headlamps and the cold weather gear and make a beeline for the cars.



The descent went quickly, the picture above being the only section that really slowed us down at all. The moon was absent so crossing back across the wide open area was 100% navigation via GPS which was a good exercise after having not carried the thing for most of last season.

We made it back to the cars by 8 pm where we rejoined our injured companion who had located a campsite for us 5 minutes down the road. We quickly set up camp and put on the heavy jackets as it was quite cold by this time. Then it was time for the traditional Sierra Club Happy Hour.

(For those that don't know one of Ron's many claims to fame is that he runs an annual gourmet backpack where everyone backpacks in to a camp and cooks food fancier than I can usually manage at home)

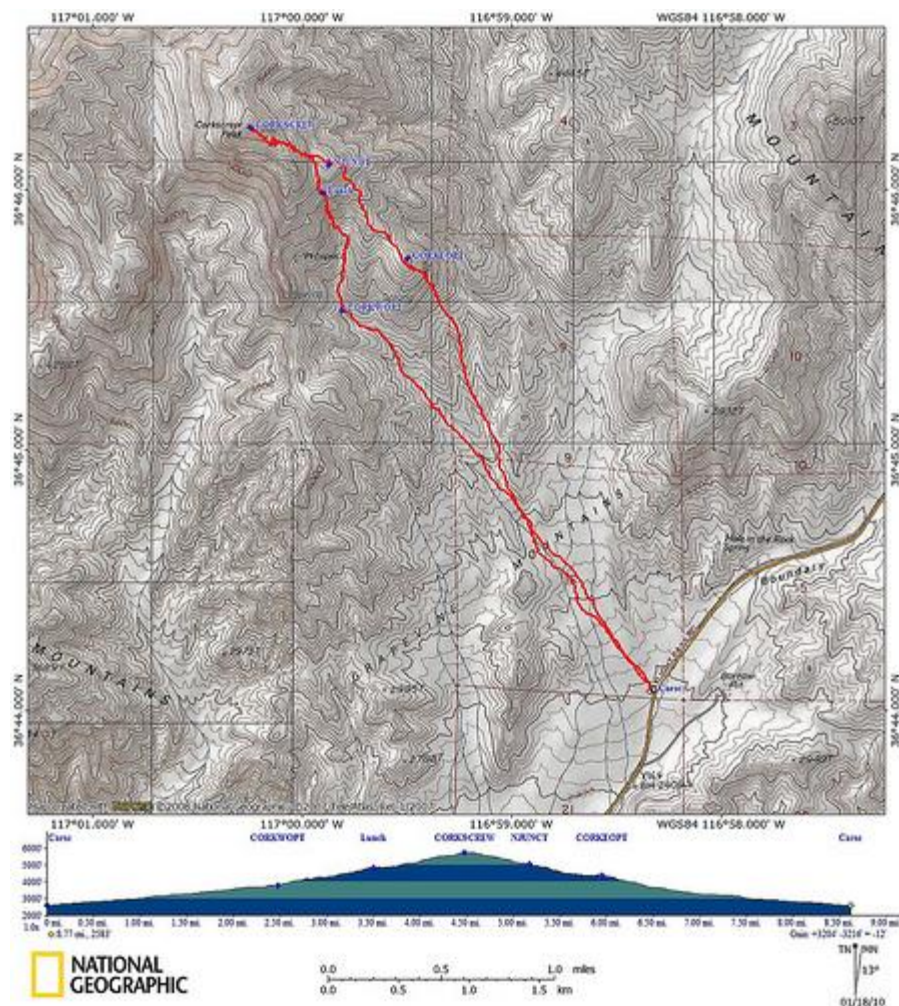
And of course, there was wine. And beer. This was a Sierra Club trip after all.

Tired, sated, and happy we all headed for the warmth of our tents or sacks. I didn't feel like setting up my tent so again I just set out my pad in the back of my truck and went to sleep.

The next morning we awoke to a few partially frozen water bottles and had breakfast waiting for the sun to warm things up.



Day 3: What do you mean it's about to rain in Death Valley?



Two of the participants from Saturday had already done today's peak and so they set out on their own to do yet another local DPS peak.

That left 6 of us and we took off in our vehicles for a roughly 80 mile drive to the trailhead for Corkscrew.

This was actually the first time I'd driven through the core of Death Valley and I must say I can't wait to go back and explore more. We made a brief stop at the Furnace Creek visitor's center to pay for our park entry and check the forecast.

It had not improved. Now instead of a chance of rain on Sunday night / Monday morning we were looking at the storm hitting that afternoon.

But we were here to hike and things didn't look bad right then so we were off.



Corkscrew is a striking peak that is visible for quite a ways. It's also one of those neat ones that look almost un-climbable from a distance. Nevertheless we parked in a dirt turnout and set out to get our last peak of the weekend.



It's hard to make out in the picture but the ground out there was covered with multicolored rocks of various sized that made for quite a visual effect.

After a long gradual approach we reached a beautiful series of dry waterfalls that proved to be the highpoint of the climb.



After that it got steep and we plugged away while I kept on eye on the clouds.





We stopped for a brief lunch part way up and then made our final assault on the peak.





Right below the summit itself it a rather distinctive hole in the rock where we stopped to take a group shot.

From there it was an easy use trail to the peak.



The peak itself was very windy and extremely cold to the point that we only stayed long enough to sign the register before Kathy led the charge down the mountain.



I brought up the rear (of course) stopping long enough to get some pictures.





The geology of the area was breathtaking.



Telescope Peak, another butt kicker hike I'm going to need to do when I get a free moment.



It was 6 hours total hiking time when we made it back to the cars and while the weather had held off admirably there was a definite feel of pending rain in the air. While I had requested a vacation day at work so I could stay over to Monday and climb Manly and Needle with Kathy I decided the chance of making it down the dirt roads and to the peak successfully was very low considering the weather. Reluctantly I joined the group that was leaving.

We made it almost to 395 before the rain started and it really came down. Kathy had actually stayed in the hope of the weather clearing but I found out they went home the following morning after clouds and drizzle had obviously been there to stay.

All in all it was a successful trip. We made all the peaks, the only incident was minor, and I got to hike my group around with headlamps (always a plus for me). And that should be it for my Sierra Club M-Rock rating though I'm still waiting on the paperwork.